Cabinet and Cabinet Committee on Accommodations. For many years the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs also dealt with foreign affairs but in recent years the Cabinet Committee on Security has emerged as the key formal body.

Under Nehru, the Cabinet Committee on Foreign Affairs comprised the prime minister, defence minister, home minister and finance minister. There were Cabinet Committee on Defence and Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs as well though none of them were 'particularly effective' in influencing the formation of policy.[17] Not only did Nehru dominate the proceedings but he often came to meetings already having decided the policy. According to Krishna Menon, Nehru 'was not a person who sought consultation' and at cabinet meetings would first lay down the issue and then in the end state 'everyone was agreed' on the policy.[18] Many non-Congress ministers in Nehru's first cabinet, like B.R. Ambedkar, resigned because they felt he took crucial policy decisions outside of the cabinet. Seeing himself as an educator for his people, Nehru was impatient to make decisions and viewed the committee process as laborious.

Currently, the Cabinet Committee on Security is the key decision-making body with respect to foreign and security policy. It is comprised of the prime minister, external affairs minister, defence minister, home minister and finance minister. It is the prime minister's prerogative to invite other cabinet ministers to these meetings. Depending on the issue being discussed, other ministers can be invited as well. The services chiefs participate whenever defence- related issues are discussed. The top bureaucratic heads – secretaries – of the ministries that are a part of the committee are also present, as is the head of the civil service, the cabinet secretary. According to protocol, a cabinet committee meeting cannot be held unless the prime minister and the cabinet secretary are both present, unless of course the prime minister designates someone in his or her place.